12.6 Steps in Merchandising



- Fashion Forecasting - Studying the fashion forecast along with the designer
- Sourcing - of fabrics- mill made, power loom, handloom, woven, knitted etc and trims such as interlining, buttons, labels etc.
- Buyer Communication - Getting information about customer profile whether be a distributor, retailer or exporter, domestic or international
- Enquiry and Sampling
- Pre-Costing - Calculating the fabric consumption and estimating the cost
- Order confirmation and acceptance
- Order Review
- Planning and Programming
- Samples
- Accessories Sourcing and Purchasing
- Inspection
- Cutting and Production
- Packing
- Shipment

At every stage merchandiser has to co-ordinate with all the departments and follows up at every process. Buyer has to be intimated about the day-to-day progress of his order and merchandiser has to ensure quality at all stages of production.

12.6.1 Fashion Forecasting

Fashion Forecasting is the process of analyzing and predicting the future trends for the upcoming season in the industry. It is very important because without it the manufacturers and retailers would not be able to produce and sell the goods. Raw material manufacturers have to be ready before one year for the selling season. Whereas apparel manufacturers and accessories manufacturers have to be ready by 9 – 12 months ahead of the selling season and retailers should prepare them at least 3 – 4 months ahead of selling season. So without forecasting these players cannot prepare and produce the right kind of style, design and type of materials.

Fashion forecasting can be done through various sources which could provide numerous information about the future fashion trends like colour, style, silhouette and designs. Some of the sources for forecasting are fashion magazines and bulletins, websites, TV channels, fashion predictive services, sales records and consumer surveys. Effective forecasting depends on how all the available information is processed analyzed and interpreted using the forecasting techniques.

12.6.2 Sourcing Materials and Production

Materials and production sourcing are critical to the success of an apparel firm. Sourcing is procuring of materials and production at a specified quality and service level. It involves a series of planned management decisions that includes merchandising, production, and marketing managers. Decisions are based on product requirements, production capabilities, lead time, and quality. A basic decision in sourcing is either to produce or buy the desired product.

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